

How is AI more harmful to the environment than social media sites (reddit, Instagram, snapchat ELC)?

Posted by u/Lean_For_Meme • 0 points • 21 comments

I've seen some Reddit comments and posts around the internet saying that AI consumes a lot of water. How is that possible? Aren't social media apps just as damaging?

Comments

u/NoMycologist2049 • 1 points • 2026-03-25 23:55 UTC

>

u/Exotic_Call_7427 • 1 points • 2025-10-24 08:18 UTC

(oversimplified explanation)

What you call AI is a program on a server (fancy computer that can be stacked in large numbers so you can run a fuckton of them in parallel). A single server can only handle a handful of people using that program. Millions of people use said program, so you need to build big-ass buildings called datacenters, with really chonky power demands and lots of water to cool those servers.

People all around the world want to use the program. So you build more datacenters.

Businesses use that program more intensively than normal people. So you build more powerful datacenters, and even more of them because the businesses can pay for it.

Websites/social media are actually much much more efficient than AI. You can build a web server that can handle millions of people in your garage. You might need a small building to house servers that serve some media. But once you have "everyone around the world" wanting to use your website or media platform, you have to build much much bigger.

u/DiogenesKuon • 2 points • 2025-10-22 16:12 UTC

AI uses an about 10x as much energy (and therefore water via cooling) for similar tasks. The thing is people scroll through instagram way more than 10x as frequently as they use a ChatGPT query. So when it comes to power and water AI isn't using massive amounts today. The problem happens if we continue to replace simpler tasks with AI it could become a huge problem.

u/djsantadad • 1 points • 2026-02-04 14:41 UTC

what's a easy way to tell people this? like how long would i have to be on facebook too equal one chat gpt question? i think a simple ratio would be good for people who don't understand (me)

6.5 minutes of scrolling per chatGPT query.

u/FrostyPresence4766 • 3 points • 2025-10-22 14:49 UTC

The fundamentals of social media are still rooted in data objects, which have a pretty linear process flow. It's just a matter of following a decision tree, gathering some of that data, putting it together and shoving it out over a wire. It takes very little processing power to begin with, and has been optimized and cached to the Nth degree.

AI relies on a form of computing which relies on massive amounts of iteration and refinement. You know how the eye doctor tries to find the best prescription for you by starting with your old prescription and then changing it a little and A/Bing them, asking "Better for worse?". Now imagine that but for pixels in frames of video, and the prompt is "Does this accurately look like a shark on a skateboard playing the guitar?".

That massively parallel style of computing is the domain of GPUs, which instead of having a few processor cores capable of handling mostly well-established processes, have thousands of cores all tasked with making those guesses and iterations. So instead of a single, mostly linear process with no wasted steps, AI is throwing obscene amounts of compute power at a problem, and most of the "work" being done is thrown out as the job progresses.

u/laddervictim • 1 points • 2025-10-22 13:08 UTC

The data centres they use aren't on a closed loop. They suck water from rivers and other sources, massive uses of electricity that the public are paying for. There's some off the coast of Scotland that are submerged in the north sea and they seem to be working. They attract wildlife and they need very little maintenance because they're pumped full of nitrogen gas so nothing oxidises

u/hwehwehwehwehwe • 1 points • 2026-03-12 00:52 UTC

No ongoing commercial submerged data centers exist off Scotland; Project Natick was experimental and shelved. "Very little maintenance" holds for the prototype due to nitrogen and isolation, but deployment/retrieval was complex. Not all data centers "suck water from rivers"—many use municipal or reclaimed sources—but direct river intake occurs in some cases.

u/sswam • 3 points • 2025-10-22 12:43 UTC

I run AI chat and high quality image gen services for ~120 active users on a single RTX 3090 GPU, which uses max 350W. It's often idle, and meets their needs. That's similar to a fridge. Three and a half old-school light bulbs, or around 1/3 of an electric heater, 1/10th of the power of a home aircon or a car driving at 60km/h.

Sure, a major international service like ChatGPT, which serves almost 1 billion users, will use some electricity and water for cooling. When you divide it by 1 billion, the cost per users is very low compared with their hair dryer, etc.

Idiots hate AI, the media doesn't understand it and misrepresents it, you can't trust liars or idiots, etc.

u/Carlpanzram1916 • 1 points • 2025-10-22 12:10 UTC

Imagine you are ChatGPT. I ask you to plan my vacation to Madrid. You read through every single website that has travel info on Madrid, mapping programs to determine the vicinity of the different places you suggest, review sites to decide which places you should recommend, and use a probabilistic equation to spit out a response that the user is looking for. That's a ton of work. And that work requires really really powerful computers. AIs really aren't very smart. They just have lots and lots

of computing power to gather data about a prompt and eventually come up with the correct answer. But it's very labor intensive. And that energy requires electricity to power processors and water to cool them.

u/HotWalk7209 • 1 points • 2026-02-12 21:16 UTC

wondering...if you went and did 10-20 google searches trying figure that all out on your own would that still be less energy than chat gpt would use?

u/jsvpz • 1 points • 2026-03-11 16:00 UTC

frr great question

u/ownworldman • 2 points • 2025-10-22 10:40 UTC

OP, do not trust any answers that does not provide numbers, units and sources.

People are really emotional about the topic, but emotional public does not mean correct.

u/Bierculles • 3 points • 2025-10-25 00:59 UTC

Seconding this, there are A LOT of people who will make confident claims and their only source is a shitty tiktok. If they do not cite actual sources and numbers it's almost certainly based on vibes and feelings and not actual statistics.

u/Lean_For_Meme • 1 points • 2025-10-22 15:00 UTC

Alright. I appreciate it, I'll take these responses with a grain of salt and I'll read in more about it

u/lreeb • 2 points • 2025-10-22 09:01 UTC

The only difference is scale. Data centers for other websites can be just as bad for the environment, the only difference is that AI needs even more processing power, and therefore even more electricity and cooling. There's also a lot of useless and unwanted AI usage, which makes the fact that it costs so many resources even worse.

We could build data centers that are more sustainable, especially if they were built in regions that have enough water, and if they were powered with renewable energy. But instead, they tend to build it where it's cheap, which is usually around small political communities that can't fight back anyway.

u/Ahimtar • 1 points • 2025-12-25 19:33 UTC

> There's also a lot of useless and unwanted AI usage, which makes the fact that it costs so many resources even worse.

This is also true for social media sites though

u/David_Aldermana • 2 points • 2025-10-22 08:40 UTC

It doesn't use much water at all, it's recycled for cooling. But it does use a lot of electricity